



La Peregrina

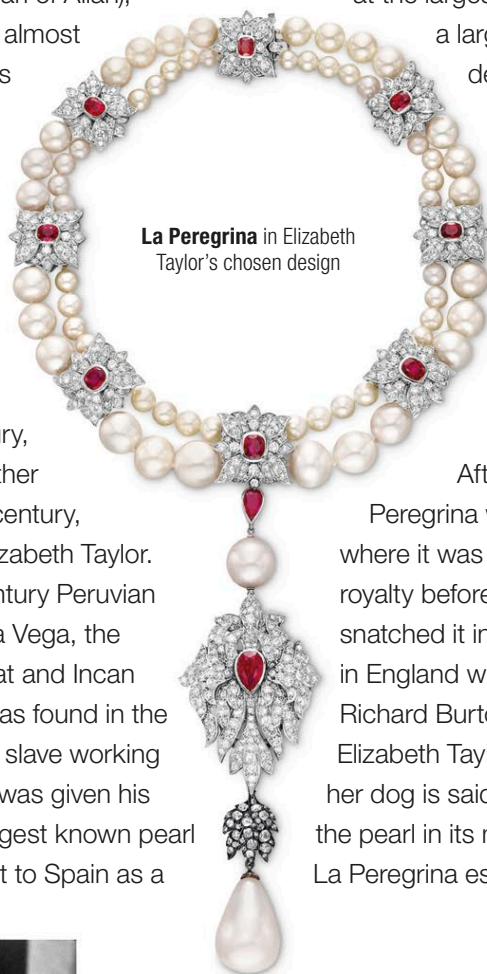
△ **La Peregrina**, a drop-shaped, 50-carat natural pearl

Although not the largest natural pearl in the world (that honour goes to the Pearl of Allah), La Peregrina's almost perfect pear shape and its bright white lustre have made it one of the most celebrated gems of the past 500 years. The other reason for the pearl's reputation is its provenance – it was worn by Queen Mary I of England in the 16th century, stolen by Napoleon's brother Joseph in the early 19th century, and owned by actress Elizabeth Taylor.

According to 16th-century Peruvian writer Inca Garcilaso de la Vega, the son of a Spanish aristocrat and Incan noblewoman, the pearl was found in the early 1550s by an African slave working in a Panama fishery – he was given his freedom in return. The largest known pearl at the time, it was brought to Spain as a

gift for King Philip II and become part of the Spanish crown jewels. "Its circumference, at the largest part, was the same as a large pigeon's egg", wrote de la Vega. It was named La Peregrina ("The Incomparable") because it was so rare. King Philip gave the pearl, hanging from a necklace, to Mary Tudor (later Queen Mary I) as an engagement present.

After Mary's death, La Peregrina was returned to Spain, where it was worn by generations of royalty before Joseph Bonaparte snatched it in 1813. It later resurfaced in England where, in 1969, actor Richard Burton bought it for his wife, Elizabeth Taylor. On one occasion, her dog is said to have picked up the pearl in its mouth – fortunately, La Peregrina escaped unharmed.



La Peregrina in Elizabeth Taylor's chosen design



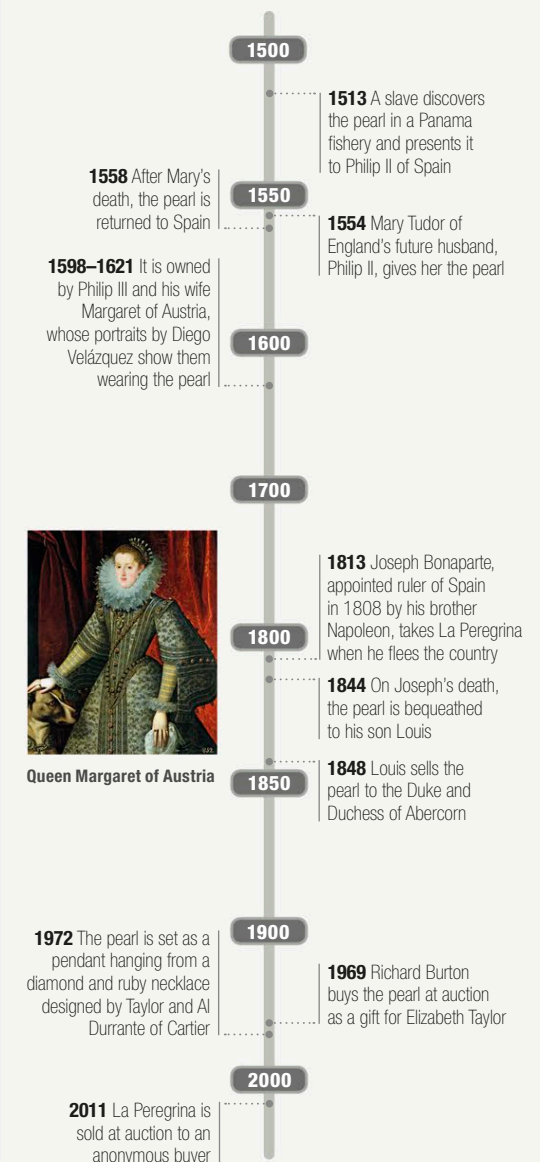
Elizabeth Taylor wearing La Peregrina in her role on the set of the film *Anne of the Thousand Days*

I was dreaming and glowing and wanting to scream with joy

Elizabeth Taylor
on receiving La Peregrina

Key dates

1513–2011



Queen Margaret of Austria